Mobility Restrictions and Reported Crime: Evidence from Staggered Lockdowns in Chile

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Abstract

We study how COVID-19 mobility restrictions affected reported crime, exploiting the staggered rollout of lockdowns across 346 Chilean municipalities (2019–2021). Using the estimator proposed by De Chaisemartin and d'Haultfœuille (2020) on monthly police records, we find that lockdowns reduced total reported crime by 21%, driven by property, violent, and public-order offenses. Gun-related and sexual offenses show no significant response, providing internal validation of the opportunity mechanism. Reported domestic violence falls initially but recovers within seven months, consistent with reporting constraints and escalating victimization rather than lower incidence; excluding domestic violence leaves the aggregate decline unchanged. These findings expose fundamental limitations of administrative crime data under restricted mobility.

JEL Codes: K42, I18, C21

Keywords: Crime, Lockdowns, COVID-19, Underreporting, Difference-in-Differences, Event-Study

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1 Introduction

Opportunity-driven crimes, which require offender–victim co-presence in mobility-driven settings (Cohen and Felson, 1979), should decline when mobility falls. COVID-19 lockdowns in Chile offer a natural experiment to test this mechanism and whether administrative crime statistics reliably capture behavioral responses under restricted mobility.

Prior work documents such declines (Poblete-Cazenave, 2024; Díaz et al., 2022; Trajtenberg et al., 2024), but it remains unclear whether they reflect a reduction in offending or in reporting. To disentangle the two, we exploit the staggered municipal rollout of Chile's *Plan Paso a Paso* lockdowns, plausibly exogenous variation in mobility across all 346 municipalities (2019–2021), analyzed with a heterogeneity-robust difference-in-differences estimator (De Chaisemartin and d'Haultfoeuille, 2020).

We find that lockdowns reduced total reported crime by 21%. Property, violent, and public-order offenses fall significantly, whereas gun-related and sexual offenses, where the mechanism predicts weaker response, show no significant effect, internally validating the mechanism.

Domestic violence is the contrasting case: confining victims with abusers while blocking reporting channels likely increased reporting barriers, so any decline in reports reflects a measurement artifact, not a behavioral response. Reported cases fall but recover within seven months—reporting constraints, not lower victimization (Bhalotra et al., 2024).

Although alternative channels (economic stress, policing intensity, and reporting behavior) could also affect crime, the offense-type heterogeneity in our design distinguishes among competing explanations. Exploiting one of the most granular municipal-level natural experiments available, we provide nationwide causal evidence that the opportunity mechanism operates uniformly across urban and rural settings, and document that administrative crime data systematically understate domestic violence under restricted mobility, exposing fundamental limits of victim-reported statistics.

2 Data

We combine two administrative sources: reported crime and municipal mobility restrictions. Crime data come from official national police records of formal complaints across all 346 municipalities at monthly frequency from January 2019 to December 2021, a balanced panel of 12,456 municipality–month observations. Our outcome is

the reported crime rate per 100,000 inhabitants, examined in aggregate and by category -property, gun-related, public-order, violent, and sexual offenses, plus domestic violence[1]- which differ in their dependence on physical co-presence and victim reporting.

Mobility-restriction data come from official Ministry of Health records of quarantine entry and exit dates under Chile's *Plan Paso a Paso*, which centrally assigned each municipality to one of five steps, from mandatory quarantine to advanced reopening, based on weekly assessments of COVID-19 incidence, test positivity, and hospital capacity. At the strictest step, residents could leave home only for essential activities, and non-essential businesses were closed. Transitions were announced 48–72 hours in advance, making anticipatory responses implausible. We code a municipality–month as locked down if it includes at least one quarantine day; results are robust to a continuous monthly-exposure measure (Appendix Figure D.1).

Chile also imposed a nationwide nighttime curfew for most of the pandemic, regardless of municipal phase. Because it applied uniformly, its common trend is differenced out when comparing switching and non-switching municipalities. To the extent the curfew already curtailed opportunity for some offenses in control municipalities, our estimates capture only the incremental effect of full quarantine beyond this baseline, a lower bound on the total impact of mobility restrictions.

3 Empirical Strategy

We analyze the staggered rollout of lockdowns within a difference-in-differences framework. Of 346 municipalities, 231 entered mandatory quarantine at least once between March and September 2020. Under staggered adoption, standard two-way fixed-effects estimators are biased (De Chaisemartin and d'Haultfoeuille, 2020). We therefore adopt Chaisemartin's non-parametric estimator as our primary specification. Formally, for a horizon of ℓ months after a municipality's first treatment change at period F_m, we estimate:

$$\widehat{DID}_\ell = \sum_{m:F_m \leq T-\ell} w_{m,\ell} \left[(Y_{m,F_m+\ell} - Y_{m,F_m-1}) - \frac{1}{|C_{m,\ell}|} \sum_{c \in C_{m,\ell}} (Y_{c,F_m+\ell} - Y_{c,F_m-1}) \right] \tag{1}$$

where $Y_{m,t}$ denotes the crime rate in municipality m at time t, and $C_{m,\ell}$ is the control pool of municipalities whose treatment status has not changed up to period $F_m + \ell$. The weights $w_{m,\ell}$ are normalized and proportional to group size. Standard errors are clustered at the municipality level. $\widehat{DID}_\ell$ identifies the incremental effect of

[1] Definitions are in Appendix A.

full quarantine beyond the baseline nighttime curfew.

We also estimate dynamic effects in an event-study over $k \in [-10, 11]$ months relative to first treatment. Post-treatment estimates ($k \geq 0$) trace the response; pre-treatment placebos ($k \leq -2$; $k = -1$ normalized) test parallel trends. Throughout, we use each municipality's first lockdown spell to avoid contamination from subsequent re-entries.

For police-initiated offenses such as public-order violations, estimates directly reflect underlying incidence. For property and violent offenses, reporting constraints could bias estimates downward; however, null effects on gun-related and sexual offenses, which share similar victim-reporting requirements but weaker predicted opportunity responses, rule out a general mobility-induced reporting suppression channel, isolating incapacitation as the operative mechanism. For victim-reported offenses, estimates capture a combination of incapacitation and measurement effects.

We assess the identifying assumption by testing whether 2019 crime and unemployment rates predict lockdown timing. They generally do not (Appendix Table C.1); The one exception, violent crime, predicts earlier lockdown entry, but with an economically negligible magnitude (0.7 months over a 20-month window). Event-study pre-trends for violent crime show no differential trend between early- and late-treated municipalities (Figure 2b), confirming the timing correlation reflects level differences absorbed by municipality fixed effects rather than a violation of parallel trends.

4 Results

4.1 Difference-in-Differences

Table 1 shows that lockdowns reduced overall reported crime by 106 cases per 100,000 inhabitants, a 21% decline relative to the pre-treatment mean. Reported property (10%), violent (15%), and public-order (27%) offenses fall significantly, consistent with the opportunity mechanism: reduced mobility limits the public co-presence these crimes require. Reported gun-related and sexual offenses show no significant response, consistent with the opportunity mechanism predicting a weaker effect for offenses less dependent on public co-presence.

Reported domestic violence also declines (26%), but this is consistent with reporting constraints and, as corroborated by Bhalotra et al. (2024) for Chile, likely escalating victimization rather than reduced incidence: lockdowns trapped victims with abusers while restricting access to police reporting, producing a net decline in

administrative records

Excluding domestic violence, the estimated decline in reported crime is 92 cases per 100,000 (still 21%), confirming that the main finding is not mechanically driven by the reporting channel.

Table 1: Difference-in-Differences Estimates of Lockdowns on Reported Crime Rates

	Lockdown	Mean Y	% change
Panel A: Aggregate			
All	-106.8^{***}	499.0	-21
	(17.6)		
All, excl. domestic violence	-92.2^{***}	442.6	-21
	(14.8)		
Panel B: Opportunity-driven offenses			
Property	-11.1^{***}	112.3	-10
	(4.9)		
Violent	-7.9^{***}	53.3	-15
	(3.3)		
Public-order	-73.0^{***}	266.0	-27
	(12.4)		
Panel C: Weaker or null-responsive offenses			
Gun-related	-2.0	5.3	-37
	(2.2)		
Sexual offenses	1.8	5.7	$+31$
	(3.3)		
Panel D: Domestic violence			
Total	-14.6^{***}	56.4	-26
	(4.6)		
Against women	-9.3^{***}	43.4	-22
	(3.4)		
Against other members	-5.3^{**}	13.0	-41
	(2.5)		

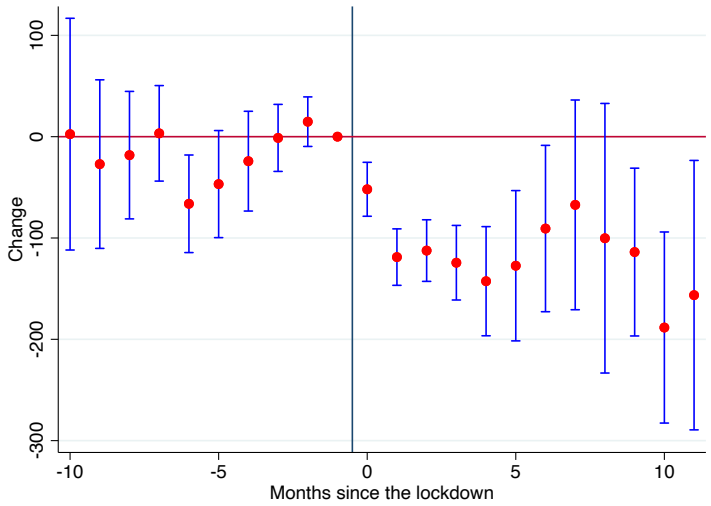
Notes: Dependent variable is the municipality-crime rate. Estimates follow De Chaisemartin and d'Haultfoeuille (2020). Clustered SEs at municipality level in parentheses. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1.

4.2 Event-Study

Figure 1 presents event-study estimates for aggregate reported crime. Reported crime declines sharply after lockdown implementation and remains below pre-treatment levels for roughly twelve months. Pre-treatment

coefficients are small, insignificant, and show no systematic pattern, supporting parallel trends. Figure D.2 shows the effect is uniform across urban and rural areas and robust to excluding the metropolitan region.

Figure 1: Event-Study Estimates of Lockdown on Reported Aggregate Crime



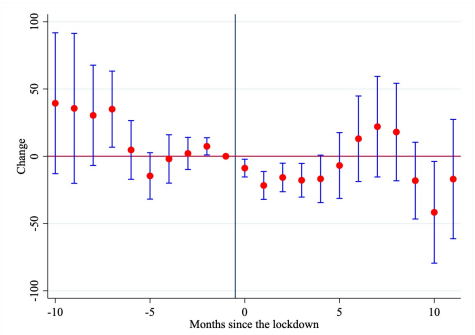
Notes: Estimates follow De Chaisemartin and d'Haultfoeuille (2020). Bars show 95% CIs. Clustered SEs at municipality level.

Figure 2 reports estimates by category. For property offenses, pre-treatment coefficients are positive in the distant pre-period while the post-treatment effect is negative; any pre-trend violation would therefore bias against the observed decline, making the estimate conservative (joint test, $p = 0.16$). For violent offenses, pre-treatment coefficients are individually and jointly insignificant with no systematic pattern, supporting parallel trends despite violent crime's correlation with lockdown timing (Appendix Table C.1). Public-order offenses show a large, persistent post-treatment decline; pre-treatment estimates alternate in sign with confidence intervals spanning zero (joint test, $p = 0.23$). This flat pre-period, combined with the sharp post-treatment break, supports a causal interpretation consistent with the opportunity mechanism.

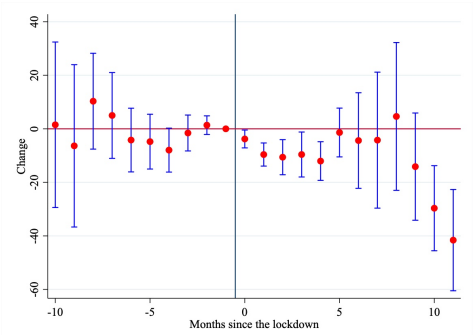
The absence of significant responses for gun-related and sexual offenses, where the opportunity mechanism predicts weaker or null effect and which face identical identification conditions, serves as an internal validity check: a broken design would produce spurious effects across all categories. The decline's specificity to offenses requiring public interaction indicates the results reflect mobility-induced incapacitation rather than a mechanical artifact of lockdown conditions.

Figure 2: Event-Study Estimates of Lockdown by Crime Category

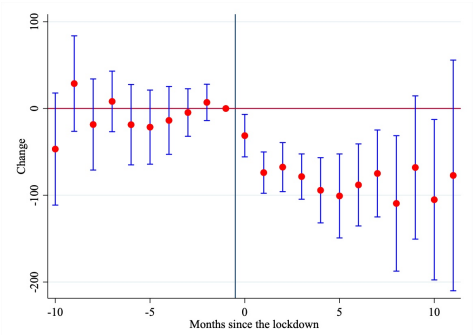
(a) Property



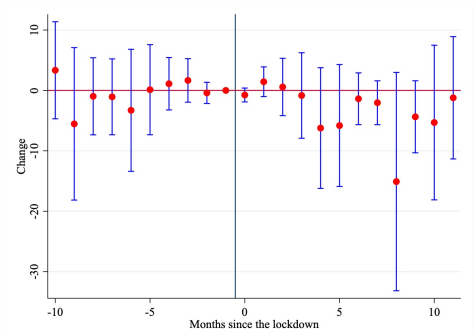
(b) Violent



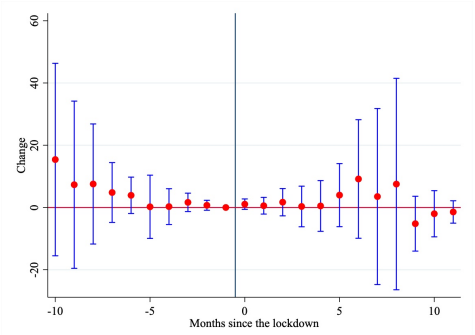
(c) Public-order



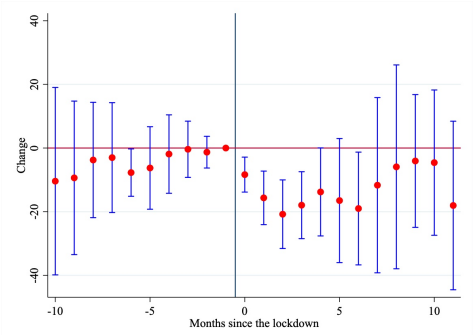
(d) Gun-related



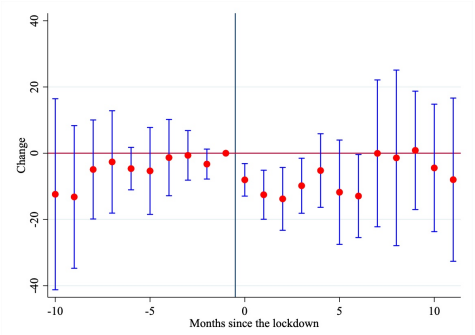
(e) Sexual offenses



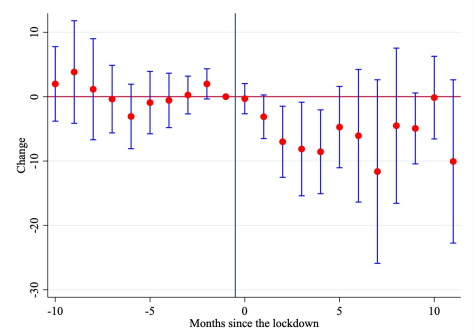
(f) Total domestic violence



(g) Domestic violence against women



(h) Domestic violence against other members



Notes: Estimates follow De Chaisemartin and d'Haultfoeuille (2020). Bars show 95% CIs. Clustered SEs at municipality level.

For reported domestic violence, pre-treatment coefficients are indistinguishable from zero, supporting parallel trends. Post-treatment, reports decline immediately but return toward baseline within seven months while lockdowns remain in effect. This within-lockdown recovery does not imply reduced victimization; it is consistent with either victims adapting to reporting constraints as the impediments identified by Bhalotra et al. (2024) ease over time, or escalating abuse driving victims to breach lockdowns to report. While our data capture reported complaints rather than actual victimization, this interpretation is directly corroborated by Bhalotra et al. (2024), who document that post-lockdown reports in Chile exceed pre-pandemic baselines by 5.6%. Consistent with the latter, they find that once lockdowns lift, reports rise 10% and exceed pre-pandemic levels by 5.6%, evidence that victimization remained elevated but uncaptured in official records. Lockdowns thus operated through two countervailing forces: restricting victims' access to reporting while intensifying underlying victimization. Similar short-run declines occurred in India and the United States (Poblete-Cazenave, 2024; Abrams, 2021).

5 Conclusion

Lockdowns reduce reported crime by 21%, concentrated in property, violent, and public-order offenses, those requiring public co-presence. Reported domestic violence also declines initially but recovers within seven months, inconsistent with durable incapacitation effects. Lockdowns likely operated through two countervailing forces: constraining victims' access to reporting while intensifying victimization by confining them with abusers, so the observed decline in police reports likely understates the true reporting gap.

The heterogeneous effects provide internal evidence on the dominant mechanism. An economic distress channel predicts rising property crime; a general deterrence or policing-intensity channel predicts uniform effects across offense types. Neither is consistent with null responses for gun-related and sexual offenses alongside large declines in property and violent crime, patterns confirmed across geographic sub-samples (Appendix Figure D.2). Notably, the null effects on gun-related and sexual offenses indicate that mobility restrictions should not be expected to reduce crimes occurring predominantly in private settings, a limitation relevant to policymakers who implement lockdowns partly on public safety grounds. These findings carry a direct policy implication for future public health emergencies. Governments and law enforcement agencies should invest in alternative reporting mechanisms including telephone hotlines, online reporting platforms, and third-party referral systems that remain accessible when physical mobility is restricted. Failure to maintain such infrastructure risks both undercounting victimization during emergencies and misallocating resources based on artificially depressed administrative

statistics.

Our findings provide nationwide causal evidence that mobility restrictions reduce opportunity-based crime while highlighting important limitations of administrative crime data: for victim-reported household offenses, official statistics may simultaneously understate incidence and misrepresent trends, a concern that extends beyond COVID-19 to any context where mobility restrictions affect victim access to reporting channels, and may be particularly acute in settings with weaker institutional capacity for alternative reporting infrastructure, where official statistics are the primary, and often only, available measure of victimization.

Declarations

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Author Contributions

Roberto Gillmore: Conceptualization, Formal analysis, Investigation, Methodology, Software, Validation, Visualization, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing.

Nicolás Rivera: Conceptualization, Formal analysis, Investigation, Methodology, Software, Validation, Visualization, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing.

Disclosure Statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors. The findings, interpretations, and conclusions are those of the authors and do not necessarily represent those of the Central Bank of Chile. The authors used ChatGPT (OpenAI) for editorial assistance in refining and editing the manuscript's text. The authors remain fully responsible for the content, analysis, and conclusions of the manuscript.

Data Availability Statement

Reported crime data can be downloaded from the Chilean Center for the Analysis and Modeling of Crime (CEAD) at https://cead.minsegpublica.gob.cl/estadisticas-delictuales. Mobility restriction data were obtained from official quarantine entry and exit dates under Chile's Plan Paso a Paso program, originally published by the Ministry of Health of Chile. The original URL is no longer active as of the time of submission. These data are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

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Online Appendix for "Mobility Restrictions and Reported Crime: Evidence from Staggered Lockdowns in Chile"

This appendix provides supplementary descriptive statistics and robustness checks supporting the main empirical analysis. We first define the crime categories used in the paper and present raw summary statistics of municipal crime rates across baseline and treatment periods and calculate a descriptive difference-in-differences. We then formally test our sorting assumptions by analyzing the structural determinants of lockdown timing. Finally, we provide alternative event-study specifications that check the sensitivity of our primary results to a continuous treatment definition and split the sample by geographic and urban-rural dimensions.

A Crime Definitions

We classify crime categories using standard international definitions from the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime's statistical classification (2015).

Property. Property crimes refer to acts involving the unlawful taking, obtaining, or damaging of property without the use or threat of force against a person. These include theft, burglary, and similar offenses.

Violent. Violent crimes are acts that involve the use or threat of physical force against a person, including homicide, assault, and other forms of bodily harm.

Public-order. Public-order offenses consist of acts that violate norms governing public behavior and social order, including disorderly conduct, public disturbances, and offenses against public authority.

Gun-related. Firearm-related crimes refer to criminal acts involving the use, possession, or trafficking of firearms. These offenses cut across multiple crime categories and are defined by the involvement of a weapon rather than the type of harm.

Sexual offenses. Sexual offenses refer to acts of a sexual nature committed without valid consent, including rape, sexual assault, and other forms of sexual violence.

Domestic violence. Domestic violence refers to acts of physical, sexual, psychological, or economic violence occurring within the family or domestic unit, or between intimate partners. This category is defined by the relationship between offender and victim rather than the specific type of offense.

B Descriptive Statistics

Appendix Table B.1 documents summary statistics for reported crime rates before and after the onset of COVID-19, partitioned by municipal lockdown status. Across all categories, average reported crime rates are consistently lower during months with active municipal quarantines. This raw descriptive pattern strongly aligns with our main finding that mobility restrictions incapacitated public-space offenses.

Table B.1: Summary Statistics of Crime Rates by Category

Crime	Pre–COVID-19			Post–COVID-19					
				Non-lockdown			*Lockdown*		
	Obs.	Mean	Std. dev.	Obs.	Mean	Std. dev.	Obs.	Mean	Std. dev.
All	4152	515.16	294.23	4923	431.20	254.97	1305	328.24	102.80
Property	4152	123.64	93.91	4923	87.18	76.50	1305	66.74	33.86
Gun-related	4152	5.21	10.43	4923	3.49	12.99	1305	3.03	5.15
Public-order	4152	271.80	218.51	4923	234.14	195.08	1305	160.65	84.71
Violent	4152	51.90	39.45	4923	41.46	34.73	1305	37.72	22.00
Sexual offenses	4152	6.04	9.74	4923	6.28	12.24	1305	5.50	5.24
Domestic violence	4152	56.56	39.93	4923	58.66	37.01	1305	54.61	24.14

Notes: "Pre–COVID-19" refers to calendar year 2019; "Post–COVID-19" covers 2020–2021. A municipality is defined as being under lockdown if it faced a mandatory quarantine for at least one day during that calendar month. Crime rates are normalized per 100,000 inhabitants and calculated at the municipality–month level. Reported values reflect unweighted averages across municipalities within each respective cell.

Appendix Table B.2 complements the summary statistics by presenting the difference-in-differences calculation suggested by the referee, with reported crime (excluding domestic violence) as the treated variable and domestic violence as the contrast case across the pre- and post-COVID periods.

Table B.2: Descriptive Difference-in-Differences: Reported Crime vs. Domestic Violence Across Alternative Post-COVID Periods

	Pre-COVID (2019)	**Post-COVID**	**Row difference (post − pre)**
Panel A: Post-COVID pooled (2020–2021, all municipality–months)			
Reported crime excl. DV (treated)	458.60	351.81	−106.79
Domestic violence (contrast)	56.56	57.81	+1.25
Difference-in-differences			**−108.04**
Panel B: Post-COVID non-lockdown municipality–months only			
Reported crime excl. DV (treated)	458.60	372.54	−86.06
Domestic violence (contrast)	56.56	58.66	+2.10
Difference-in-differences			**−88.16**
Panel C: Post-COVID lockdown municipality–months only			
Reported crime excl. DV (treated)	458.60	273.63	−184.97
Domestic violence (contrast)	56.56	54.61	−1.95
Difference-in-differences			**−183.02**

Notes: This table follows the difference-in-differences framework suggested by the referee, with reported crime (excluding domestic violence) as the treated variable and domestic violence as the contrast case. Pre-COVID refers to 2019. Panel A uses pooled 2020–2021 municipality–months as the post period, following the referee's suggested structure. Panel B uses only non-lockdown municipality–months as the post period (the comparison group). Panel C uses only lockdown municipality–months as the post period (the treated group). All figures are unweighted averages of reported crime rates per 100,000 inhabitants drawn from Appendix Table B.1. The difference-in-differences subtracts the domestic violence row difference from the reported crime row difference within each panel. Across all three panels, reported crime excluding domestic violence falls substantially more than domestic violence, consistent with the opportunity mechanism documented in Table 1. The Panel A DiD (−108.04) is closest to the causal estimate of −92.2 in Table 1; the descriptive figures are slightly larger because they do not account for staggered treatment timing and pre-existing trends, which the De Chaisemartin and d'Haultfoeuille (2020) estimator addresses. Domestic violence is included as a conceptual contrast case: it faces the same lockdown treatment as other crime categories but through a different mechanism (reporting constraints rather than opportunity reduction), as documented in the main analysis.

C Balance Test

To validate our difference-in-differences identification strategy, Appendix Table C.1 models the institutional determinants of lockdown implementation. We estimate a cross-sectional regression where the dependent variable is the exact calendar month of a municipality's initial lockdown entry, evaluated against 2019 baseline crime rates,

labor market indicators, and demographic features.

Table C.1: Determinants of First Lockdown Timing (2019 Baselines)

Panel A: Crime rates			
Violent	-0.021***	Property	-0.001
	(0.007)		(0.003)
Public-order	0.002	Domestic violence	-0.008
	(0.002)		(0.012)
Gun-related	0.005	Sexual offenses	0.061
	(0.057)		(0.076)
Panel B: Labor market			
Male unemployment	0.006	Female unemployment	-0.035
	(0.030)		(0.057)
Panel C: Demographics			
Population	-0.000015***	Rural	1.240**
	(0.000003)		(0.504)

Notes: All coefficients come from a single regression and are based on 2019 municipal averages. The dependent variable is the continuous month-year of a municipality's initial quarantine entry. The sample includes municipalities that entered a lockdown between March 2020 and March 2021 (N = 271). "Rural" is an indicator variable equal to one if more than 50% of the municipal population resides in a rural locality. Region FE are included. Clustered SEs at municipality level in parentheses. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1.

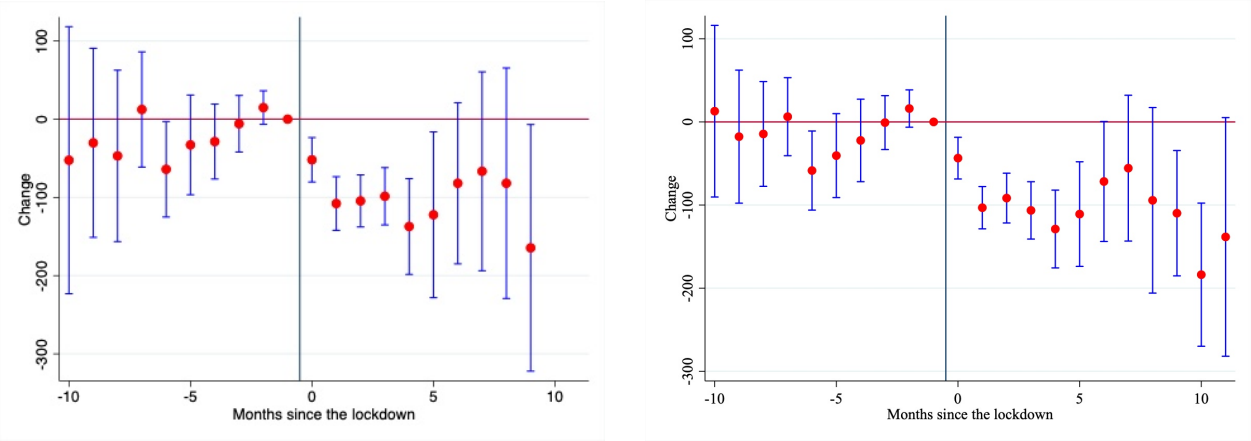
Reassuringly, baseline socio-economic distress and crime rates are not systematic predictors of quarantine timing. Neither male unemployment ($p = 0.848$) nor female unemployment ($p = 0.534$) display any statistically detectable relationship with policy adoption, demonstrating that local economic vulnerability did not bias the rollout timeline. Similarly, five out of six crime categories, property ($p = 0.721$), domestic violence ($p = 0.504$), gun-related ($p = 0.934$), sexual ($p = 0.423$), and public-order offenses ($p = 0.160$), exhibit no statistically significant relationship with the start date of local restrictions. While historical violent crime rates show a statistically significant coefficient ($p = 0.005$), the effect is economically minor: a full one standard deviation increase in baseline violent crime (around 34.9 cases) accelerates lockdown adoption by less than three weeks (0.7 months) within a 20-month policy window. As shown in the main paper's dynamic event-studies, this minor level difference is completely absorbed by municipal fixed effects and does not induce pre-treatment divergent trends.

Instead, lockdown timing was overwhelmingly driven by objective demographic and epidemiological conditions. The coefficient on population size is negative and highly significant ($p < 0.001$), showing that large urban centers were targeted early to buffer regional healthcare capacity. Conversely, the rural index exerts a large, positive, and statistically significant effect ($p = 0.014$). This confirms that geographically isolated, sparsely populated rural municipalities entered lockdowns substantially later, safely insulated by low initial transmission velocity.

D Robustness and Geographic Heterogeneity

To verify that our main conclusions are not sensitive to our specific treatment definition, where a municipality-month is coded as treated if it includes at least one day under lockdown or driven by distinct sub-samples, we execute two extensions. First, we substitute our baseline binary treatment dummy with a continuous measure: the exact share of days within a given month that a municipality spent under mandatory quarantine. Appendix Figure D.1 replicates our primary event-study under this intensive-margin definition, confirming that our main findings are robust to variations in treatment intensity.

Figure D.1: Event-Study Estimates of Continuous Lockdown and Crime Rate without Domestic Violence



(a) Continuous

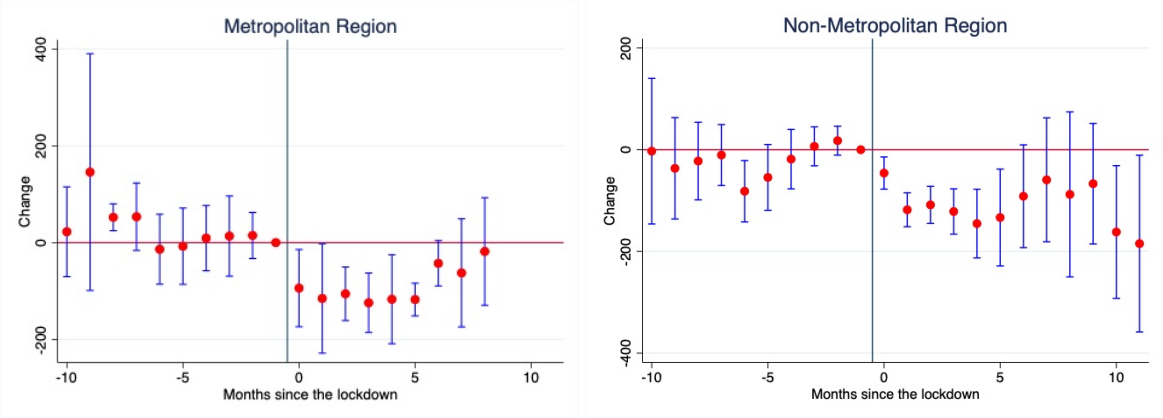
(b) All, excl. domestic violence

Notes: The dependent variable is the aggregate monthly municipal crime rate per 100,000 inhabitants. In figure (a), the treatment is defined continuously as the share of days within a month that a municipality was subject to full lockdown mandates. In figure (b), the treatment is a binary indicator for whether the municipality was under lockdown, and the dependent variable includes all crimes except domestic violence. Estimates follow De Chaisemartin and d'Haultfoeuille (2020). Bars show 95% CIs. Clustered SEs at municipality level.

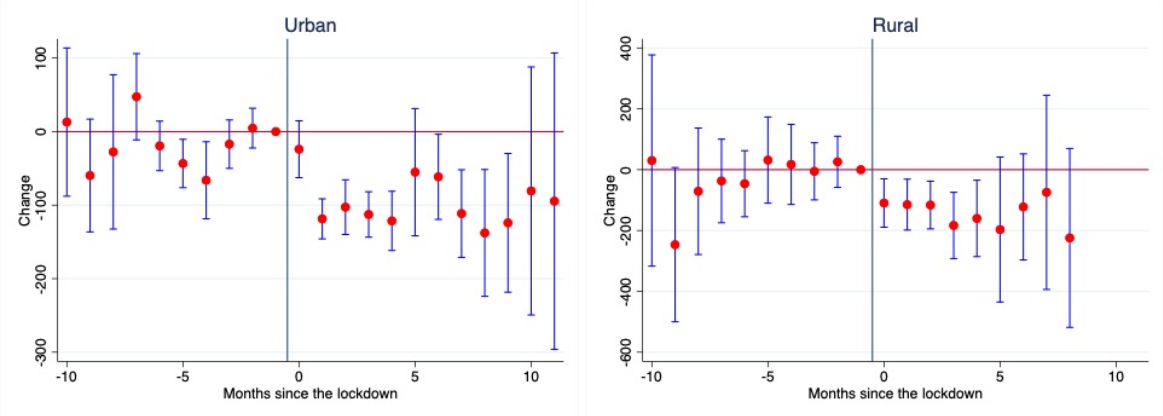
Second, we split our sample across regional and structural dimensions to verify the external validity of our estimates. Appendix Figure D.2 presents separate event-studies comparing the Santiago Metropolitan Region against all remaining administrative regions, as well as strictly urban municipalities against rural ones. The estimated treatment tracks are strikingly uniform across all geographic sub-samples, demonstrating that our documented crime suppression is a nationwide phenomenon rather than an artifact of large metropolitan areas.

Figure D.2: Event-Study Estimates by Regional Location and Urban Status

(a) Regional location



(b) Urban or Rural location



Notes: Urban designation follows the national statistical agency's definition based on local population density and concentrated urban settlement shares. The treatment is defined continuously as the proportion of days within the month that a municipality faced full quarantine mandates. Estimates follow De Chaisemartin and d'Haultfoeuille (2020). Bars show 95% CIs. Clustered SEs at municipality level.

These sub-sample exercises yield two critical insights. First, they provide strong evidence that the opportunity mechanism operates independently of baseline municipal characteristics. Urban centers like the Santiago

Metropolitan Region feature vastly different built environments, socio-economic profiles, and baseline crime levels compared to peripheral or rural municipalities. The fact that mobility restrictions yielded nearly identical percentage reductions in crime across these diverse settings suggests that physical co-presence is a universal structural binding constraint for opportunity-driven offenses.

Second, the consistent drop observed in rural areas helps rule out alternative institutional explanations, such as shifts in police strategy or localized capacity constraints. During the pandemic, law enforcement resources were heavily concentrated in major cities to enforce sanitary cordons and secure critical infrastructure. If our main results were primarily driven by changes in policing intensity or shifts in local police behavior rather than a drop in public interaction, we would expect to see sharp divergences between urban and rural areas. The uniform treatment tracks across all sub-samples reinforce our primary conclusion: the incapacitation effect of lockdowns is fundamentally driven by the reduction in baseline human mobility.